ATOLE DE CACAO

serves 4

It's believed the Olmec people were the first to cultivate and process cacao and use it to make drinks. For the Maya people, cacao was a sacred food but also consumed daily, much like corn. (In fact, it was often blended with ground corn to make a warm drink like this one.) For people in the Aztec empire, cacao was seen as more special and generally drunk by the elites.

Before colonization, cacao-based drinks were rarely sweetened.

Today, you'll find many warm, often spiced and sweetened cacao-based drinks throughout Mexico. This is a fairly traditional version, unsweetened (unless you'd like to add some agave syrup) and flavored with ancho chile powder and vanilla. It uses the ancient Maya method for aerating by pouring the atole back and forth, although you could use a molinillo or whisk to do so.

- ½ cup unsweetened cacao nibs or ⅓ cup cacao powder
- ½ cup masa harina
- 2 cups pepita milk (see Seed, Nut, and Grain Milks, page 35)
- Pinch of ancho chile powder
- ½ vanilla bean, split lengthwise
- Agave syrup (optional)

Using a metate or spice grinder, grind the cacao nibs into a powder.

In a medium bowl, stir together the masa harina and 2 cups water and let stand for 5 minutes.

Strain the masa and water through a fine-mesh sieve directly into a saucepan, pressing all the solids through. Bring to a simmer over medium heat. Add the ground cacao and stir constantly to try to dissolve.

Stir in the pepita milk and allow it to heat through. Add the chile powder. Scrape in the vanilla seeds and simmer very gently for 5 minutes, allowing the flavors to meld and the masa to thicken the drink slightly.

Pour the drink back into a jicara (a bowl made out of a gourd) or another saucepan and continue pouring it back and forth to aerate it, mix it further, and help it become frothy. (Alternatively, you could use a molinillo or whisk.)

If you'd like to enjoy the atole the way the Maya and Aztec people would, pour it into cups without sweetening. Otherwise, sweeten with agave syrup to taste before serving.

SEED, NUT, AND GRAIN MILKS

makes 1 quart

Dairy came with European colonization, and the livestock that people brought changed the landscape of Turtle Island, which is why I typically avoid it in my kitchen. Traditionally, some Indigenous groups would pound nuts and seeds and blend the mixture with water to make rich porridges or creamy liquids. So strained seed, nut, and grain milks like the ones here aren't far from tradition.

Each seed or nut has its own distinctive flavor, and nut milks tend to feel the most creamy because of their rich fat. At Owamni, I use wild rice and pepita milk most often, but I also let the region where I am inspire me. For example, in the South, I'd use pecan milk. In the Northwest, hazelnut.

1 cup sunflower seeds, pepitas, pecans, black walnut pieces, skinned hazelnuts, or uncooked wild rice, soaked overnight in 6 cups of water

Pinch of sea salt

Maple syrup (optional)

Drain the soaked nuts, seeds, or grains, then rinse and transfer to a blender, preferably one that's high-powered. Add 4 cups fresh water and the salt and blend until very smooth.

Line a sieve with two layers of cheesecloth or a clean kitchen towel and pour in the nut milk. Pull up the cloth around the puree and twist to squeeze. (Alternatively, use a nut-milk bag to drain.) Whisk in a little maple syrup, if desired, to sweeten.

If desired, reserve the pulp for another use (see Notes).

Notes

- *To deepen the flavor of the milks, you can toast the seeds first before soaking.*
- *You can use the pulp in place of nut flours or bran in baked goods or add it to smoothies.*

SWEET CORN MILK

makes about 3 cups

I reach for sweet corn milk whenever I want to enhance the flavor of other corn in the dish. For example, it brings more sweetness to the Green Corn Soup (page 167). You could also use it in place of some of the water for the Indigenous-Inspired Shrimp 'n' Grits (page 142).

2 cups sweet corn kernels (from 2 to 3 large ears)

Pinch of sea salt

In a blender, combine the corn, 2 cups water, and the salt. Puree until very smooth.

Line a sieve with two layers of cheesecloth and set over a bowl and pour in the puree. Pull up the cloth around the puree and twist to squeeze the corn milk into the bowl. (Alternatively, use a nut-milk bag to drain.) Discard the solids. Refrigerate for up to 3 days.